

Tracing State-Sanctioned Anti-Blackness and the War on Drugs in the Black Panther Party Historical Archive

Created by: Nyla McNeil

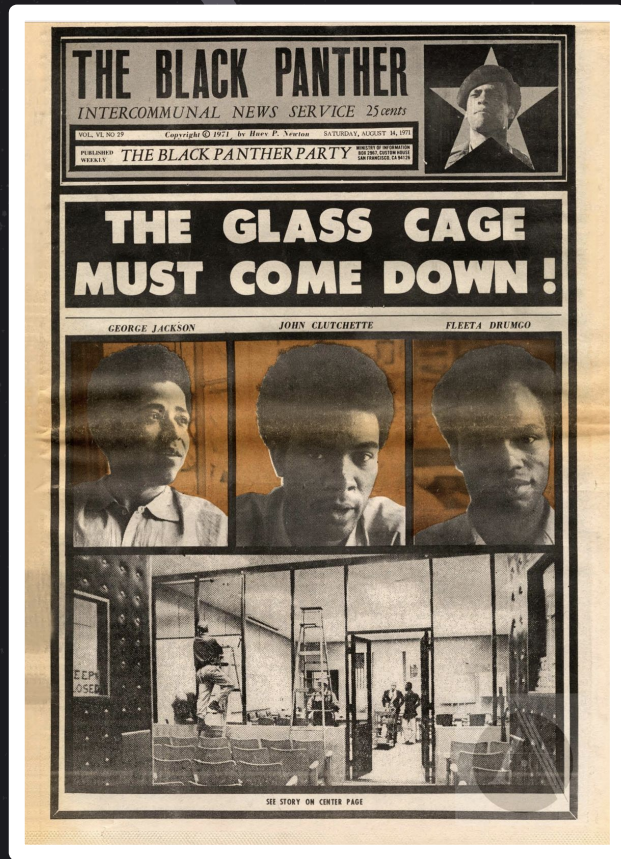


Table of Contents

01

Project Overview

02

Methodology

04

Early Insights

05

Next Steps



01

Project Overview

Research Questions

How can an examination of the political actions of the Black Panther Party in the late 20th century offer insight into the origins of the War on Drugs and its role as a political project connected to anti-Black government policies?

What approaches did the government use to racialize recreational drug consumption and deploy it as a tool for racial control and subjugation?

Brief Background of the War on Drugs

- In June of 1971, President Richard Nixon officially declared a “War on Drugs”, publicly indicating that drug abuse was public enemy number 1
- Created the Special Action Office for Drug Abuse Prevention (SAODAP)
- Created the DEA (Drug Enforcement Administration) in 1973

Interview with John Ehrlichman, domestic policy advisor of Richard Nixon:

*“The Nixon campaign in 1968, and the Nixon White House after that, had two enemies: the antiwar left and black people ... We knew we couldn’t make it illegal to be either against the war or black, but by getting the public to associate the hippies with marijuana and blacks with heroin, and then criminalizing both heavily, **we could disrupt those communities. We could arrest their leaders, raid their homes, break up their meetings,** and vilify them night after night on the evening news. Did we know we were lying about the drugs? Of course we did.”*

02

Methodology

Black Radicals as Architects of History

THE BLACK PANTHER, SATURDAY, AUGUST 16, 1970 PAGE 5

LETTER TO WESTMORELAND



General Westmoreland



U.S. Army General

YOU ARE COMMITTING THE SAME BRUTALITY AGAINST SOUTH VIETNAM SOLDIERS THE MORE CLOSER IS A LATE LIFE AGAINST YOUR FAMILY & MINE.

Department of the Army
Headquarters, 24th Transportation
Battalion (Terminal)
APO SF 96312

W.C. Westmoreland
General, United States Army
Chief of Staff
Washington, D.C. 20310

Dear General Westmoreland:

I have decided to communicate with one of the people that controls the people that think they control me and my contemporaries. I declined to exercise the chain of command because experience has shown me that my so-called leaders, designated by the ruling class, are not qualified to handle the contents of this letter. Below is a very brief paragraph of my prior military life.

Entrance into the Army was in April 1969 for a period of three years. I have no record of disciplinary action. I am a personnel specialist (71120) and have performed this duty at all times while a member of your Army. If some members of your organization don't kill me first, I'm due for rotation in November, 1971.

I request immediate discharge from

the organization that over-exploits, destroys minds, feeds the fires of hate and denies adequate support for my beautiful Black mother and progressive mankind. I know, for a fact, and believe that the perpetrators of this war, and all wars, do not care whether or not I save my loved ones again. I have completed more than two-thirds of my enlistment contract and the records show that this service has been determined honorable. I cannot/will not continue on in this war. I, like all people, have a conscience. My sympathies are with the Viet Cong; so how can I play the role of representative of America in Vietnam. Rather than request, I demand immediate discharge for the good of the service. The assumption is that you are an intelligent man, I want you to review this letter with that point of view.

A soldier's life is difficult, especially if he is a thinking man. If the soldier is Black, the difficulty is multiplied tenfold. If the Black G.I. is thinking, his very presence spells trouble...from all sides, I speak from experience and my beautiful mother, whom you people neglect, taught me that it (experience) is the best teacher. There have been occasions when I displayed military courtesy though I abhor the vicious reality of

your flag, stripes and eagles; by keeping me in the military, you are depriving me of the inspiration I desire. This inspiration is not mandatory, but it is helpful. If you don't release me, I'm still going to educate the people to the vicious ways of the machine.

I slide once again, release me so that I can be with those that I love...the true patriots...the sons of Star's Patch...with the minds of Malcolm X.

I deliberated long before writing to you. You may send out your reactionary forces as a result of this letter but, we, you too, all are destined to die one day. At the rate your subordinates are moving, they are trying to make my death premature.

I relate to other (all) members that are victims of your major apparatus. Do you realize that your Vietnamization/Pacification is forcing the Vietnamese people to serfdom. (Years ago my people cleaned your rooms and your apertures were forced into... of women). General, you have been to Vietnam; isn't that what is happening now? Do have subordinates in Indo-

CONTINUED ON PAGE 16

WEB TEXTS VIDEO AUDIO SOFTWARE IMAGES

ABOUT BLOG EVENTS PROJECTS HELP DONATE CONTACT JOBS VOLUNTEER

NYLA MONEY

Black Panther
by Newsweek

Add to list Favorite

THE BLACK PANTHER

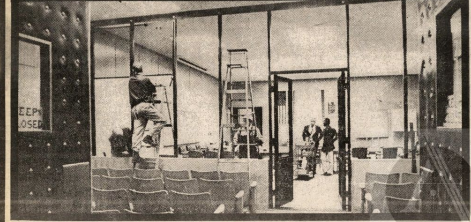
INTERCOMMUNAL NEWS SERVICE 25 cents

WOL, VL, RD 18 Copyright © 1971, by Elbert P. Stevens SATURDAY, AUGUST 16, 1971

PUBLISHED BY THE BLACK PANTHER PARTY

THE GLASS CAGE MUST COME DOWN!

GEORGE JACKSON JOHN CLUTCHETTE FLEETA DRUMGO

SEE STORY ON CENTER PAGE

02

Early Insights

Findings and Incomplete Thoughts

1. Drug related prosecutions as life sentences:
 - a. Disruption of formerly incarcerated individuals capacity of find work/earn money/become upwardly mobile/housing access.
 - b. Dessimation of the Black Household
2. Different faces of a “War”
 - a. Neighborhoods are terroized by overpolicing
 - b. Communities live in constant fear of subjugation
 - c. Blackness as a criminalized state of being

02

Next Steps

To-Do:

- Identify additional primary sources for research use
- Develop coding guide for critical assessment of primary sources
- Close reading of Black theoretical contributions:
 - Trouillot (Silencing the Past)
 - DuBois (Black Reconstruction in America)
 - Mariame Kaba (We Do This 'Til We Free Us)